

Modes

Modes are variants of the major and minor keys, and are based on modal scales. Most modal scales are similar to, but slightly different from, major or natural minor scales.

Modes and the major scale

There are seven main types of mode: Ionian, Dorian, Phrygian, Lydian, Mixolydian, Aeolian, and Locrian. Modal scales use the same notes as the major scale, but each modal scale starts on a different note of the major scale.

▽ **Modes and modal scales**
This table shows the seven modes, and the starting position and note of their modal scales using only the white keys of the keyboard.

Mode	Note of major scale that is starting note of modal scale	Starting note of modal scale using only the white keys
Ionian	1 st note (tonic)	C
Dorian	2 nd note (supertonic)	D
Phrygian	3 rd note (mediant)	E
Lydian	4 th note (subdominant)	F
Mixolydian	5 th note (dominant)	G
Aeolian	6 th note (submediant)	A
Locrian	7 th note (leading note)	B

SEE ALSO

◀ 60–61	Major scales
◀ 62–63	Minor scales
Degrees of the scale	124–125 ▶
Folk, world, and roots	202–203 ▶

REAL WORLD

Ralph Vaughan Williams

Many folk songs are in Dorian, Lydian, Mixolydian, and Aeolian modes. The composer Ralph Vaughan Williams was a collector of folk songs, and his music features a lot of modal folk tunes. His *English Folk Song Suite*, for example, includes folk melodies in Dorian and Mixolydian modes.



Modal scales

Shown here are the seven main modal scales using only the white keys of the keyboard. If the same modal scale starts on a different note, the pattern of whole steps and half steps must be maintained by using some black keys.

 Whole step  Half step

59 ▽ **Ionian mode**
The Ionian modal scale is exactly the same as the major scale. Music in a major key is, therefore, also in Ionian mode.



60 ▽ **Dorian mode**
The Dorian modal scale is similar to the natural minor scale, but its sixth note is one half step higher.

